

The developments in technology with content distributed across different digital platforms has made regulation more complex. However, the BBC's role as a self-regulator seemingly challenges Livingston and Lunt's assumption that 'new media' is harder to regulate. The BBC has considered the access of potential audiences and regulated within the institution. For example, in February 2021, the BBC received 564 complaints regarding a *Woman's Hour* interview with Zara Mohammed, the first female leader of the Muslim Council of Great Britain. The main issue was an accusation of bias and the hostile questioning style of presenter Emma Barnett. The BBC subsequently removed the clip of the interview from digital platforms.

PART 2: STARTING POINTS – Audiences

The RAJAR figures for radio for 2021 showed that 34.51 million people tuned in each week across all radio stations. There were 257 million downloads of BBC podcasts and on-demand radio programmes on third-party platforms globally. Radio 4 had 10.48 million listeners each week. 'These figures show the important role that BBC Radio plays in people's lives, with 34.5m tuning in to listen live each week to our much loved stations. We also continue to see on-demand listening grow for both our radio programmes and podcasts, as audiences come to BBC Sounds to discover content to listen to whenever they want to'. – Charlotte Moore, BBC Chief Content Officer

(<https://www.bbc.com/mediacentre/2022/live-listening-figures-revealed-with-34m-tuning-in-to-bbc-radio-each-week>)

Consider how audiences interpret the media, including how and why audiences may interpret the same media in different ways:

- Consider, for example, a **male response** to the content of the show. Think about how many other media texts are composed of only female members (*Loose Women*, for instance, has male guests) and how this might be unsettling or alienating for male listeners. Compare this to a **female audience** and consider whether or not this same gender composition might be appealing to some female audiences who feel their concerns are underrepresented.
- Woman's Hour* encourages an interactive relationship with their listeners. Audiences can respond to *Woman's Hour* on Twitter, through the website and on other **social media platforms**. The broadcast has been designed to invite audience members to enter the discussion through social media platforms. Audience's often offer very different viewpoints in their responses, which are read out at the end of sections of the programme during the live broadcast and at the end of the Saturday omnibus edition. This creates additional discussion and debate around topics which may continue on social media platforms.

Consider how media organisations reflect the different needs of mass and specialised audiences, including through targeting:

- As a **PSB**, the BBC has a **remit** to produce content for all audience **demographics**. Consider whether *Woman's Hour* has been designed to explicitly appeal to a **specialised** female audience as part of the remit of the organisation itself. An extension of this discussion might consider whether there are any other media products that appeal to this specific target audience on the radio (BBC or otherwise).
- Specialised audiences contribute to the diversity of the BBC and enhance the profile of Radio 4 as a station that caters for a broader demographic. In the case of *Woman's Hour*, it is through the choice of presenters, guests and topics selected.
- The programme airs a range of serious and more light-hearted stories to appeal to the demographic. In one week in March 2022, content included the release of Nazanin Zaghari-Radcliffe, body hair in history, growing up in poverty, domestic abuse and the first black Superwoman.
- Advances in technology have enabled radio audiences to access content across a range of digital platforms to suit their needs. Some audiences will loyally listen to the daily programme whilst others will 'catch-up', selecting the episodes that match their interest and concerns. Audiences can subscribe to the podcast '*Woman's Hour Daily*' to catchup on episodes and be notified when new ones are released.